



IFDC RESOURCE • NO. 6

IFDC TRAINING TOOL

YARDSTICKS FOR ASSESSING NEWS ABOUT CHILDREN

A fifteen-point scoring framework for evaluating child-focused news coverage

A PUBLICATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD

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YARDSTICKS FOR ASSESSING NEWS ABOUT CHILDREN

A fifteen-point scoring framework for evaluating child-focused news coverage

This assessment tool helps journalists, editors and journalism students evaluate how well a published news item respects and reflects a child's rights, safety and dignity. It was originally developed by Dr. M. C. Rasmin for the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) after reviewing internationally recognised reporting on children, and is offered here for use in newsroom training and journalism education across Sri Lanka.

How to Use This Tool

1. Read through all fifteen yardsticks before beginning the exercise.
2. As a group, agree on a priority order for the fifteen yardsticks, ranking them 1 to 15 based on which matter most for the type of coverage being assessed.
3. Distribute a total of 100 points across the fifteen yardsticks, weighting each according to its agreed priority.
4. Select three recent published news items — your own outlet's or examples provided by a trainer — and score each one against every yardstick.
5. Total each item's score and be ready to explain the reasoning behind it.
6. Write up how the priority order was decided, and how the 100 points were divided among the fifteen yardsticks.
7. Justify the overall score given to each of the three news items.
8. Discuss how consistently these yardsticks are reflected across mainstream Sri Lankan media — print, broadcast and online — today.

The Fifteen Yardsticks

- 1. Offers readers practical support** — Points readers — including parents and caregivers — toward health, counselling or safety information when a story covers a distressing incident.
- 2. Restores a child's sense of confidence** — Avoids re-victimising a child victim; content leaves them, and readers, with a sense of agency rather than further exposure.
- 3. Pushes for accountability** — Follows up on whether authorities are acting — investigation status, prosecution, policy response — in cases of child abuse or neglect.
- 4. Safeguards privacy** — Does not compromise a child's identity, location or personal details, whether directly or through accumulated detail.
- 5. Meets ethical and legal standards** — Complies with Sri Lankan law (Penal Code, Harmful Publications Act) and the Editors' Guild / PCCSL Code of Professional Practice.
- 6. Goes beyond the surface** — Offers genuine insight into the issue affecting the child, not just a restatement of the incident.
- 7. Explores the story in depth** — Provides context and background rather than treating the event as an isolated occurrence.
- 8. Is grounded in verified data** — Uses accurate statistics and research — for example NCPA, Department of Census and Statistics, or UNICEF Sri Lanka data — to support claims.

9. Keeps the focus on the issue, not the child's identity — Minimises personal identifying detail while still addressing the underlying problem clearly.

10. Considers long-term impact — Discusses how the event or issue could affect the child's future, not only the immediate incident.

11. Uses child-friendly language — Written in terms accessible to a general and younger audience, avoiding unnecessary jargon.

12. Protects children who are especially vulnerable — Applies extra care for children with disabilities, in state care, displaced, or otherwise at heightened risk.

13. Presents balanced perspectives — Reflects a range of relevant views and voices connected to the issue.

14. Treats child victims with respect — Demonstrates sensitivity and dignity throughout the reporting and language used.

15. Includes children's own voices where appropriate — Reflects children's perspectives as a genuine source, not only adults speaking on their behalf.

Scoring Worksheet

Use the table below in training sessions, editorial reviews, or journalism classrooms to score real news items against these criteria.

Rank	Yardstick	Score (of 100)	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3
	Offers readers practical support				
	Restores a child's sense of confidence				
	Pushes for accountability				
	Safeguards privacy				
	Meets ethical and legal standards				
	Goes beyond the surface				
	Explores the story in depth				
	Is grounded in verified data				
	Keeps the focus on the issue, not the child's identity				
	Considers long-term impact				
	Uses child-friendly language				
	Protects children who are especially vulnerable				
	Presents balanced perspectives				
	Treats child victims with respect				
	Includes children's own voices where appropriate				
	Total Score	100			

Applying This in the Sri Lankan Media Landscape

Trainers and newsroom leads can sharpen this exercise by testing it against real patterns in Sri Lankan coverage. Consider discussing:

- How often crime reporting on child victims names or visually identifies the child, in contrast to Section 365(C) of the Penal Code and the PCCSL Code's Section 6.2 restrictions.
- Whether coverage of NCPA-reported cases (the 1929 helpline received roughly 40 complaints a day in 2020) includes follow-up on outcomes, or stops at the initial incident.
- Whether stories about children affected by poverty, displacement, or the estate sector move beyond a single image toward context and data, such as figures from the Department of Census and Statistics' child statistics portal.
- Whether coverage across Sinhala, Tamil and English-language outlets applies these yardsticks consistently, or whether standards vary by language or platform.

Developed by Dr. M. C. Rasmin for the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), presented here in paraphrased form with added Sri Lankan media-landscape discussion points for use in newsroom and journalism training. © IFDC — www.ifdchild.org.

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Sri Lankan Bodies Every Journalist Covering Children Should Know

EDITORS' GUILD OF SRI LANKA

No. 96, Kirula Road, Colombo 05, Sri Lanka

Self-regulatory body for editors — Code of Professional Practice

PRESS COMPLAINTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (PCCSL)

96 Bernard Soysa Mawatha (Kirula Road), Colombo 00500

Web: www.pccsl.lk

Independent Dispute Resolution Council for complaints against the press

HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (HRCSL)

No. 14, R. A. De Mel Mawatha, Colombo 04

Tel: 011 250 5580 / 011 250 5581 / 011 250 5582 · Hotline: 1996

Web: www.hrcsl.lk

LEGAL AID COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA

No. 129, Hulftsdorp Street, Colombo 12

Tel: +94 11 243 3618 / +94 11 533 5329 / +94 11 533 5281

Email: legalaids@sltnet.lk · Web: www.legalaids.gov.lk

Free legal advice and court representation for eligible persons, including in child-related matters

NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION AUTHORITY (NCPA)

No. 330, Thalawathugoda Road, Madiwela, Sri Lanka

Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24 hours, trilingual) · Tel: +94 11 277 8911–14

Email: ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk · Web: www.childprotection.gov.lk

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